

READING PASSAGE 2

The Evolution of Human Language

A The study of the evolution of human language has undergone a remarkable transformation over the past several decades. What was once a niche area of academic inquiry has developed into a rich and diverse field of research, drawing on insights from a wide range of disciplines and theoretical traditions.

B The intellectual lineage of this field extends considerably further than many realise. While modern research techniques have only recently been applied to these questions, philosophers and natural scientists have grappled with related issues for centuries. The transition from speculative philosophical inquiry to systematic empirical investigation represents one of the most significant developments in the intellectual history of this domain.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D A substantial body of empirical evidence supports these theoretical frameworks. A landmark study conducted by researchers at leading international institutions analysed data spanning a thirty-year period and involving participants from more than forty countries. The findings revealed a consistent pattern of results that held across diverse cultural and economic contexts, suggesting that the identified mechanisms operate with considerable universality. The magnitude of the observed effects was particularly striking, with the key variables accounting for a substantial proportion of the total variance in outcomes.

E Despite the substantial progress that has been made, significant challenges and controversies remain. Critics have raised important methodological concerns regarding the generalisability of findings derived from studies conducted in specific contexts. The predominance of research carried out in Western, educated, industrialised, rich, and democratic societies raises questions about the applicability of current theories to populations with different cultural, economic, and political circumstances. Furthermore, the reliance on cross-sectional designs in much of the existing literature limits the capacity to draw strong causal inferences.

F Looking ahead, the field stands at a critical juncture. Emerging technologies offer unprecedented opportunities for data collection and analysis, potentially enabling researchers to address questions that have long remained beyond the reach of empirical investigation. At the same time, the accelerating pace of social and technological change means that the phenomena under study are themselves evolving, requiring theoretical frameworks that can accommodate dynamism and discontinuity rather than assuming stability and equilibrium.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Questions 1–2

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 1 Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?
- A. economic incentives and institutional constraints
 - B. individual personality traits
 - C. random chance
 - D. government policies alone
- 2 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
- A. pessimism about the future
 - B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
 - C. complete certainty about outcomes
 - D. indifference to practical applications

Question 3

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 3 Early researchers had access to the same technologies as modern scholars.

Questions 4–6

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 4 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
- A. minimal impact
 - B. creating underlying conditions for action
 - C. determining individual choices directly
 - D. irrelevant to outcomes
- 5 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
- A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration
- 6 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
- A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration

Questions 7–8

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 7 Policy-makers have fully implemented all research recommendations.
- 8 Meta-analyses have confirmed the reliability of the core findings in this field.

Questions 9–12

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 9 According to the passage, structural factors include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and _____.
- 10 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.
- 11 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.
- 12 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.

Question 13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 13 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.